

and put him to bed to sleep. Then she washed his clothes, spread them out in the scorching sun, dried and mended them; when the orphan woke up, she dressed him and waited for her husband's return.

In the evening, when Krikor-the-Saddler came home, Tourvanda Korro took the orphaned infant in her arms, stood before her husband, and said:

'“There should be a kid in the house,” you used to say. Well, here's one: you can pretend that it has dropped from my loins.'

Tourvanda Korro and Krikor-the-Saddler had been married for twenty years, but in spite of their fervent efforts—they had lit countless candles in front of pictures of saints—they had not produced any children.

Krikor-the-Saddler looked lengthily at Torrig, who was smiling away with a foolish air. He took pity on the child and, releasing a tolerant smile from behind his moustache, took him from his wife's arms, kissed him, and said:

'God has turned His eyes upon us again.'

'What would have happened to him, if it wasn't for us?'

'He would have been thrown among the street urchins in the ash-mounds of the bath-house,' replied Krikor-the-Saddler.

Tourvanda Korro once more cried for her poor, unfortunate sister, who was already resting in the cemetery, and upon whom was spread the deep shadow of the mulberry tree.

Both Tourvanda Korro and Krikor-the-Saddler developed a deep love for Torrig. They both felt anew the tragedy of having no children of their own; but barely a few months had gone by when it seemed to them that he was born and bred in their house. As for Torrig, he was an amazing child: he would neither cry nor would he get into mischief; he would stay wherever they put him down; he would wake up in the morning in the position they had laid him to sleep the night before; if they gave him food, he would eat it, if they did not, he would not ask for it.

'Torrigh, lad,' would cry out Krikor-the-Saddler when he returned home from the shop, 'how are you?'

Torrigh would turn his head round calmly, he would gaze at Krikor-the-Saddler and smile vacantly.

'He is God's lamb,' Tourvanda Korro would say.

'He is a little like a cow,' Krikor-the-Saddler would disagree. She would glare at her husband angrily.

And Tourvanda Korro would sit Torrig on a mattress which she would spread on the floor and she would say to him:

‘Torrig, my precious soul, I am going to the market to buy some things. You sit here on the mattress and play.’

Then Tourvanda Korro would shut the door and go to the market; and even if she did not return for hours, Torrig would not go beyond the limits of the mattress.

When Krikor-the-Saddler remarked one day:

‘There is no fire in him at all!’

His wife replied:

‘Don’t talk like that! God has already dealt him a blow: he is an orphan!’

Krikor-the-Saddler remained silent, but he could never reconcile with the thought that a son of his own would not have been such a miserably stupid child. Without any good reason, he believed that if he had had a son, he would have been different: an exceedingly lively, bright, and clever boy.

No one knew what made him think so.

Krikor-the-Saddler often spoke with feeling about this subject. One day, Tourvanda Korro lost her patience and said angrily:

‘You couldn’t produce anything all these years. You became the father of a ready-made child, and now you don’t like him!’

Krikor-the-Saddler became silent about this subject once and for all.

And Torrig grew up. He had big, strong bones, but his head remained relatively small.

‘His head is very small,’ remarked Krikor-the-Saddler one day, even though he had long decided not to say anything.

Tourvanda Korro did not leave him without response:

‘Let it be small; what can we do about it? We are not going to crack nuts on his head!’ she retorted.

‘It would be better if it grew a little bigger, so that something could get inside it!’ growled Krikor-the-Saddler.

Tourvanda Korro did not answer, but she glared at him in a peculiar way.

And it would happen that Krikor-the-Saddler would take Torrig out for walks. When Krikor became entangled in conversation with somebody in the street, Torrig would wrap his arms round the saddler’s leg, and he would stand there quietly.